



From *Space Invaders* to *Tetris* to *Quake III* and beyond. Tracing the birth and growth of that mind-changing substance—games

From *Space Commanders* and *Pong* of yesteryear to the photo realistic graphic accelerated games of today. From a handful of 2D sprites to millions of textured polygons. From simple straightforward script driven enemies to ‘bots’ that learn and adapt to your behaviour. From single player adventures to elaborate online game worlds with the interactivity and complexity of a small country. The quantum leaps in concepts, creativity and technology in the gaming subculture are staggering. But as the saying goes, Rome wasn’t built in a day. There’s another saying that goes “One does not sell the land people walk on” which however has nothing to do with this article. Anyway, for those who missed the bus, here’s a history class on gaming, attendance is not compulsory. No grades or tests or term papers.

Back when digital watches were still ‘droolmaal’ and computers were the size of a blue whale, an MIT nerd called Steve ‘Slug’ Russell decided to create the ultimate hack, an interactive game. After 200 hours of coding he created one in 1961—two rocket ships that fired torpedoes at each other. He called it *Spacewar*. Soon

everybody wanted one just like it. To fire imaginary rockets at imaginary spaceships was indeed tapping into a raw, powerful instinct deep inside. Every homo sapien who saw it salivated at the prospect of firing rockets in the comfort of their own home. Enter the era of the game console.

1972: The Game Odyssey

The Magnavox Odyssey, designed by a military electronics firm was introduced at a price of \$100. With only 40 transistors and 40 diodes, the console was so primitive that players had to jot down the score on a notepad. You had to place a screen overlay on the TV screen as part of the graphics. Those were indeed trying times to live in. Soon Atari stepped in and took this concept further, introducing the *Pong* arcade machine. The gameplay was simple. Two players controlled a vertical bar each that could bounce a dot between them. *Pong* became an instant success and it created the arcade video game industry.

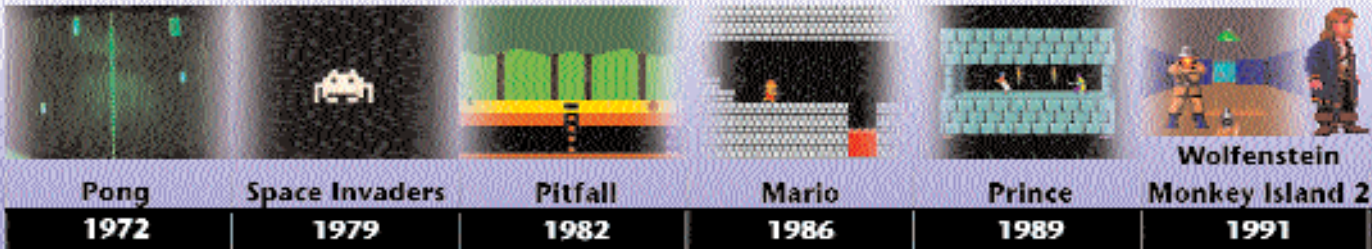
Space Invaders was the first blockbuster videogame. It brought video games into arcades, bars, restaurants and corner stores and to the public. It was translated to the Atari 2600 video game system. The home version too turned into a huge commercial

hit. Atari was the forerunner of consoles back then, with its cutting-edge 2,600-games system. Drool over the specs of this monster: 8-bit CPU at 1.19 MHz, 16-colour graphics, two-channel audio (noise and sound), 128 bytes of RAM. This was the era of games such as *Pac-Man*, *Centipede*, *Asteroids*, *Space Invaders*, and *Tempest*.

The dawn of PC gaming

During the early 1980s, a promising personal computing revolution made it possible to play a different variety of games. Text-based adventures such as *Zork*, *Hitchhiker’s Guide to the Galaxy*, and *Wishbringer* took gaming to a different level altogether. By 1985, Infocom’s *Zork* sold more than 1,00,000 copies. Gaming had arrived, and with it companies such as Electronic Arts and Sierra established themselves.

Games diversified into different genres. Role Playing Games (RPGs) that were played with dice were ported to the PC, adventure games told their stories with graphics, and 2D games made tentative attempts at simulation. *Civilisation* and *XCOM* established themselves as forerunners of the strategy genre. MUDs, or multi-user dungeons, became popular in universities and wherever terminals were



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